DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL

THE INDIAN PET PARENT PLAYBOOK

2026-27 Edition

Complete Care, Vet and Diwali Safety Guide for Dogs and Cats

EVERY RULE, FEE AND DATE VERIFIED FROM OFFICIAL SOURCES

WSAVA | WHO and NRCP | Supreme Court and CPCB | AWBI and PCA Rules
MCD, BMC and Greater Chennai Corporation | Indian Railways and IRCTC | IRDAI insurers

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How to use this playbook

Read Part 2 and Part 3 before you choose a pet. Read Part 15 today if you already have one - Diwali 2026 falls on Sunday 8 November, and the noise starts on Dhanteras, Friday 6 November. Everything else you can read at your own pace, but Parts 5, 6, 7 and 16 are the ones that save lives.

Prices are shown in rupees as they stood in October 2026. Vaccination schedules follow the World Small Animal Veterinary Association (WSAVA) guidelines adapted for India, where rabies is endemic. Nothing here replaces your own vet, who knows your animal. When this book and your vet disagree, your vet wins.

Part 1 - Why This Playbook, and India's Pet Boom in Numbers

India has fallen hard for its pets, and it happened fast. In 2019 Indian households held about 26 million pets. By 2024 that figure had reached roughly 32 million, and industry projections put it near 60 million by 2030. Euromonitor counts about 40 million pet dogs and four million pet cats in the country today. The pet care market, measured by retail value, was around Rs 6,300 crore in 2025 and is growing at more than 15 per cent a year.

The most important number for this book is a different one. Around 70 per cent of Indian pet parents are first-timers, against a global average of 47 per cent, and some estimates put the share of first-time owners above 90 per cent. In mature markets most owners grew up with a dog. In India most are learning everything from scratch, from vaccination schedules to what a frightened dog does on Diwali night. That gap between love and know-how is exactly what this playbook is written to close.

39M	70%+	66%	15%
PET ANIMALS IN INDIA (FY25)	FIRST-TIME PET PARENTS	SAY THEIR PET IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PART OF LIFE	ANNUAL MARKET GROWTH

The warmth is real and so is the money. Indian pet parents spend on average about Rs 50,000 a year on their animals, roughly 5 to 8 per cent of household income, and about 80 per cent of that goes on food, grooming and healthcare. This book is about spending that money well, and about avoiding the expensive mistakes that cost far more than they save.

Three things changed the law and the culture recently, and all three affect you directly. City after city made pet registration and microchipping compulsory, with real fines for ignoring it. The Supreme Court spent 2026 examining India's firecracker noise rules, the single biggest annual welfare event in an Indian pet's calendar. And the Animal Birth Control Rules, 2023 rewrote how the country manages its street dogs, which shapes everything from feeding a community dog to adopting one. Each gets its own part below.

The shape of the Indian pet household has changed too. The fastest-growing segment is the young, urban, double-income couple with a dog or a cat and no children yet - a group the industry calls DINKWAD. They are time-poor and willing to spend, and they want reliability over discounts: a vet they trust, a boarding place that will not lose their dog, a groomer who is actually trained. Tier-2 cities are catching up fast, and cat ownership is rising more quickly than dog ownership because cats suit smaller flats. Whatever your household looks like, the practical knowledge you need is the same, and it is what this book gives you.

One warning runs through everything that follows. India's pet market is formalising, and with money has come a wave of products, supplements and services that are marketed far beyond what they can do. The most expensive option is rarely the best one. A monthly spot-on, a complete diet, a current vaccination card and a good vet will keep your pet healthier than any shelf of premium accessories. Spend on the fundamentals first; the rest is optional.

Who this is for

This playbook is written for the first-time Indian pet parent - the student who just brought a pup home, the young couple with a cat in a Bengaluru flat, the family that adopted an indie. It assumes no prior knowledge and no expensive lifestyle. Every rupee figure, rule and date has been checked against official sources, and where a rule varies by city or state, the book tells you where to check your own.

Part 2 - Before You Bring a Pet Home: The Honest Readiness Check

A dog lives 10 to 15 years and a cat can live past 18. That is the length of the commitment you are making, and the single most common reason pets end up abandoned in India is that nobody sat the family down and did this arithmetic first. Chennai now fines owners Rs 10,000 for abandoning a registered pet, precisely because the problem got big enough to legislate against. So answer these honestly, before you fall in love with a face.

The five questions that actually matter

- **Time.** A puppy needs to be fed three to four times a day, taken out every few hours, and exercised. An adult dog needs at least two walks a day. Who does this on the days you are at work, travelling or unwell? Name the person.
- **Money.** The first year costs Rs 60,000 to Rs 1,00,000 for a small or medium breed and more for a large one. That is before any emergency. Can your household absorb a Rs 20,000 vet bill without a crisis?
- **Space and rules.** If you rent, does your agreement allow pets? If you live in a society, what does the resident welfare association say? Getting this wrong is how animals get surrendered.
- **Who is in charge.** One person must be the primary caregiver - the one who notices when the dog is off its food. A pet owned by a whole family and cared for by nobody is a pet that suffers.
- **Travel and change.** People move cities, marry, have children and change jobs. Will the animal move with you in each of those scenarios? If the honest answer is 'probably not', wait.

How long they live

Animal	Typical lifespan	Notes
Indie dog (Indian pariah)	13 to 15 years	Hardy, low grooming cost, fewer inherited problems
Small purebred dog	12 to 16 years	Some breeds carry inherited conditions
Large purebred dog	8 to 12 years	Higher risk of joint disease and some cancers
Cat (indoor)	12 to 18 years	Indoor cats live far longer than outdoor ones

The cost of getting this wrong

The most expensive pet in India is the one that was bought on impulse and surrendered six months later. A pedigree puppy bought and then given away costs you the purchase price, the first-year care, and the animal its home. The cheapest pet in the long run is the one you were genuinely ready for.

Part 3 - Adopt or Buy: The Law, the Truth, and How to Choose Well

This is the decision with the biggest effect on both your wallet and an animal's life, and Indian law has a clear position on it.

What the law says

Breeders must register with their State Animal Welfare Board under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Dog Breeding and Marketing) Rules, 2017. The registration costs Rs 5,000, is valid two years, and carries hard conditions: no pup under eight weeks may be sold, any dog over six months must be sterilised before sale, every pup must be microchipped, and health and vaccination records must be handed to the buyer. Pet shops are separately regulated under the PCA (Pet Shop) Rules, 2018, which require registration with the State Board before they may open at all. PETA India's assessment is blunt: most pet shops and breeders in the country are operating illegally because they are not registered.

Why the 'cheap' pedigree is usually the expensive one

A registered, well-run breeder is not the problem. The problem is the informal market that supplies most Indian pet shops: puppies bred continuously, taken from their mothers too young, kept in crowded conditions, and sold without records. Those puppies arrive with worms, kennel cough and sometimes parvovirus, and the first vet bill can exceed what you paid. Flat-faced breeds - pugs, bulldogs, boxers, shih tzus, Pekingese - carry an additional, permanent cost: their shortened airways make breathing and cooling hard, and they are two to fourteen times more likely to suffer heatstroke than a Labrador. The Indian pariah or 'indie' is the opposite bargain: adapted to the climate, robust, low grooming cost and largely free of the inherited problems that purebred lines carry.

Where to adopt in India

- Animal Welfare Board of India (AWBI)-recognised animal welfare organisations and shelters in your city. The AWBI publishes a list on its website.
- Municipal and NGO pounds - many cities now allow animal lovers to adopt a sterilised, vaccinated street dog directly, a route the Supreme Court expressly permitted in 2025.
- Rescue groups on social media, who foster dogs and cats and can tell you the animal's temperament before you commit.
- Ask always for the vaccination and deworming record and the approximate age. Both matter for the schedule in Part 5.

Signs of a bad breeder or pet shop

- Cannot show a State Animal Welfare Board registration certificate.
- Sells pups under eight weeks old.
- Has no microchip number, no health record and no vaccination card.
- Keeps many animals in small, dirty cages, or will not let you see where they are kept.
- Pushes you to decide today, or offers a 'discount' for cash with no paperwork.

The temperament rule

Choose for temperament and your lifestyle, not looks. A high-energy working breed in a small flat is a hard life for everyone. A calm, medium-energy animal that fits your real daily routine will be healthier, better behaved and far cheaper to keep than a beautiful animal that does not fit your life.

Part 4 - The First 30 Days at Home

A new pet is disoriented, not naughty. For the first weeks the goal is safety, routine and calm, in that order.

Days 1 to 3: keep it small

- Confine the pet to one quiet room, not the whole house. A crate or a corner with a bed, water and a puppy pad is a den, not a cage, if it is never used as punishment.
- Feed the same food the pet was already eating, then transition slowly over 7 to 10 days if you are changing it. A sudden change causes diarrhoea.
- Keep visitors away. Let the animal come to you. Do not let children carry it around.
- Take puppies out to toilet every two hours, and immediately after waking, eating and playing.

Puppy-proofing, room by room

- Electrical wires, phone chargers and extension boards: block or cover them. Chewed live cable is a common and fatal accident.

- Medicines, cleaning fluids and phenyl: behind a closed door or a high shelf. Paracetamol is fatal to cats in particular.
- Shoes, socks, plastic bags, hair ties and sanitary items: out of reach. These cause intestinal blockages that need surgery.
- Balconies and windows: net or block. A frightened or curious pet can clear a railing faster than you can react.
- Plants: check Part 7 and Part 20. Lilies, in particular, must never be in a home with a cat.

First-week checklist

Do this	Why it matters
Register with a vet and save the number	You need a named vet before the first problem, not during it
Fix meal times and a toilet spot	Predictability is what makes a nervous animal feel safe
Set up the crate or bed and leave it open	A den the pet chooses is a refuge, not a punishment
Photograph the vaccination card	Travel, insurance and registration all depend on it
Book the vaccination course	The window for the final puppy dose closes at 16 weeks

Settling in a cat, and introducing pets to each other

A cat needs its own room first, with food, water, a litter tray and a hiding place, and should be allowed to come out on its own terms over several days. When introducing a new pet to an existing one, keep them separated at first and swap bedding so they get used to each other's smell, then allow short, supervised meetings. Never leave a new and an old pet alone together in the first weeks, and never punish either for growling or hissing - that is normal communication, not aggression.

By the end of the first month the pet should have a fixed feeding schedule, a fixed toilet spot, a bedtime, and short positive encounters with new people, sounds and surfaces. Until the vaccination course is complete, keep a puppy away from street dogs and public parks - but do carry it in your arms to see traffic, people and noise, so the socialisation window is not wasted.

Part 5 - Vaccination: The Complete Schedule for Dogs and Cats

Vaccines are the cheapest thing you will ever buy for your pet, and the schedule below follows the World Small Animal Veterinary Association (WSAVA) guidelines, which Indian veterinarians use as their standard. There are two kinds of vaccine. **Core** vaccines protect against diseases that are everywhere and often deadly, and every dog and cat should get them. **Non-core** vaccines are given when your animal's location or lifestyle puts it at risk - in India, leptospirosis is usually treated as core because the disease is common.

Dogs - core vaccination schedule

Vaccine	Protects against	Puppy schedule	Booster
DHPPi (core)	Distemper, hepatitis (adenovirus), parvovirus, parainfluenza	First dose at 6-8 weeks; repeat every 3-4 weeks until 14-16 weeks	At 1 year, then no more often than every 3 years
Rabies (core in India)	Rabies - fatal once symptoms appear	One dose from 12 weeks (3 months)	At 1 year, then annually (Indian law and practice)
Leptospirosis	Leptospirosis, spread by rat urine in water	First dose from 8 weeks; second 2-4 weeks later	Annually
Kennel cough	Bordetella and parainfluenza	Before kennel, daycare or boarding exposure	Annually, if at risk

The one rule people get wrong: the **final puppy dose must be given at 14 to 16 weeks**, not earlier. Mother's antibodies can block a vaccine given too young, so a puppy that finishes its course at 10 weeks may not be protected. If your vet offers an early finish so the pup can go outside sooner, ask whether a third dose at 16

weeks is planned.

Cats - core vaccination schedule

Vaccine	Protects against	Kitten schedule	Booster
Tricat (core)	Feline parvovirus (panleukopenia), calicivirus, herpesvirus	First dose at 6-8 weeks; second at 10-12 weeks	At 1 year, then every 1-3 years
Rabies (core in India)	Rabies	One dose from 12 weeks	Annually
Feline leukaemia (FeLV)	Feline leukaemia virus	For kittens at risk, from 8-9 weeks	Per product datasheet

Deworming runs alongside vaccination

Vaccines protect against viruses; deworming protects against intestinal worms, which are common in Indian puppies and can stunt growth. Puppies are usually dewormed every two weeks until 12 weeks, then monthly to six months, then every three months for life. A deworming dose costs about Rs 150 to Rs 300. Skipping it is a false economy - worms weaken the animal and can pass to children who play with the puppy.

Vaccination records are legal documents

Keep a written vaccination card, and photograph it onto your phone. Indian Railways and airlines require it for travel (Part 15), pet insurance requires it for claims (Part 17), and your municipal registration depends on a current anti-rabies certificate (Part 14). One card, photographed, solves all four.

Part 6 - Rabies: The Emergency Every Indian Pet Parent Must Understand

India carries the world's heaviest rabies burden - roughly a third of global deaths - and domestic dogs cause about 99 per cent of human cases. The disease is almost always fatal once symptoms begin, and almost always preventable if you act in the first hour. Every Indian pet parent needs to know three things: how to wash a bite, when to get the vaccine, and why vaccinating your own dog is a public duty and not just a personal choice.

If a person is bitten or scratched

- **Wash immediately** with soap and running water for a full 15 minutes. This single step removes the virus from the wound and is the most effective first aid there is.
- Apply an antiseptic such as povidone-iodine after washing.
- Do not apply chilli, oil, turmeric, lime, salt, ash or herbs. India's National Rabies Control Programme prohibits these - they do nothing and delay real care.
- Go to a hospital or anti-rabies clinic the same day, however minor the bite looks.

The post-exposure vaccine schedule (India)

Route	Doses	Days	Visits
Intramuscular (IM)	1 full vial per dose	0, 3, 7, 14, 28	5
Intradermal (ID)	0.1 ml per site	0, 3, 7, 28	4

Exposures are graded. Category I (touching or feeding an animal, licks on intact skin) needs no vaccine. Category II (minor scratches without bleeding) needs the vaccine course. Category III (any bite that breaks the skin, or saliva on broken skin or a mucous membrane) needs the vaccine **and** rabies immunoglobulin injected into the wound. In a rabies-endemic country like India, treatment starts immediately after any dog or cat bite - do not wait to 'observe' the animal first.

If your own pet bites someone

- Wash the wound as above and send the person to a hospital the same day. Do not try to decide yourself whether the bite was 'serious enough'.
- Have your pet's vaccination certificate ready. A current anti-rabies record is your protection as an owner.
- Keep your pet under observation for ten days as your vet advises; a healthy dog or cat that remains well through that period reassures the bite victim.
- Understand your liability: if your dog injures a person or damages property, you are legally responsible. Third-party liability cover, available in Indian pet insurance policies, exists for exactly this.

Your dog's rabies vaccine is a shield for your street, not just your home

The World Health Organization's position is unambiguous: vaccinating dogs is the most cost-effective way to prevent rabies in people, because it stops the virus at its source. India aims to eliminate dog-mediated human rabies by 2030. A single unvaccinated pet dog that bites a child is a public-health event. Keep your dog's anti-rabies certificate current - annually - and keep the paper.

Part 7 - Feeding Your Pet Right: The India Edition

Most Indian homes feed their pets some version of what the family eats - rice, dal, curd, roti, a little chicken. Done carelessly, this is the most common cause of slow, invisible malnutrition in Indian pets. Done thoughtfully, it works. The difference is protein and planning.

The number that matters

A dog needs roughly 2.2 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight per day, and a cat needs about 4.5 grams - against about 1 gram for a human. Rice and roti are mostly carbohydrate, so a bowl of plain rice and dal leaves most dogs short on protein, and cats short on the amino acid taurine, a deficiency that can cause a fatal heart condition called dilated cardiomyopathy.

If you want to feed vegetarian

- Build every meal around a real protein: paneer, curd, boiled moong or chana, soya chunks, tofu, or eggs if your household allows them. Rotate two or three across the week rather than relying on one.
- Add a vet-recommended supplement covering taurine, vitamin B12, iron, zinc and an omega-3 source (algal oil for vegetarian homes). These are the nutrients plant food supplies poorly, and deficiencies build over months before you see them.
- Never use onion or garlic in the tadka. Both are toxic to dogs and cats.
- For a puppy, a pregnant or nursing dog, or any animal with a health condition, get the diet formulated by a vet. The margins are tighter and the stakes higher.
- The safest route is a commercial diet labelled 'complete and balanced'. A home recipe off the internet is almost always deficient in something.

Rough portion guide (adult dog, commercial dry food)

Dog's weight	Food per day	Meals
5 kg	About 90-120 g	2
10 kg	About 150-200 g	2
20 kg	About 250-330 g	2
30 kg	About 350-450 g	2

These are starting points, not prescriptions - activity, age and brand all change the number. Your vet or the food packet's weight chart is the real guide. Treats should be no more than about one-tenth of daily calories, or the animal gains weight while eating 'properly'.

Foods that are genuinely dangerous

Food	What it does	Especially
Chocolate, coffee, tea, energy drinks	Methylxanthines cause vomiting, racing heart, tremors, seizures	Darker chocolate is worse
Grapes and raisins	Kidney damage or failure	Dogs
Onion, garlic, chives, leek	Damages red blood cells, causes anaemia	Cats more sensitive
Xylitol (sugar-free gum, candy, some toothpaste)	Dangerous drop in blood sugar, liver failure	Dogs
Macadamia nuts, alcohol, raw yeast dough	Weakness, tremors, poisoning, bloating	Dogs
Paracetamol / acetaminophen	Fatal to cats even in small doses	Cats
Lilies (all parts, even pollen and vase water)	Fatal kidney failure within 24-72 hours	Cats - keep them out of the house
Bones, especially cooked	Splinter and block or tear the gut	Dogs and cats

Mithai season warning

Diwali sweets are the single most common poisoning source for Indian pets. Chocolate, raisins and kheer made with xylitol-sweetened ingredients are all dangerous. Tell every guest, before they arrive, not to feed the dog or cat from the table. It is easier to say once than to explain at a midnight vet clinic.

Part 8 - Ticks, Fleas and Heartworm: India's Year-Round Threat

In much of the world, parasite prevention is seasonal. In India it is not. A national survey found that just under half of the dogs tested carried at least one tick-borne pathogen, and India's warm, humid climate keeps ticks and mosquitoes active across the year, with a clear spike in the monsoon. The diseases here have local names - 'tick fever' - and local weight: a single untreated case can kill.

The three threats

Threat	Spread by	What to watch for
Tick fever (ehrlichiosis)	Brown dog tick	Fever, swollen lymph nodes, lethargy, pale gums, nosebleeds
Babesiosis	Tick	Fever, anaemia, yellow gums, dark urine
Heartworm	Mosquito bite	Cough, tiredness, weight loss - often late and serious

Ehrlichiosis is treated with doxycycline for a full 28 days; shorter courses often fail to clear the infection. Treatment is far cheaper than the disease, and prevention is cheaper still. Heartworm is the cruellest of the three because the dog can look fine for months; treating adult heartworm disease costs tens of thousands of rupees and is hard on the animal.

Prevention, in plain terms

- Use a monthly spot-on or chewable tick and flea treatment, every month, all year. A spot-on costs roughly Rs 400 to Rs 1,500 a month depending on size and brand; a good collar lasts several months.
- Ask your vet about monthly heartworm prevention from about eight weeks of age - typically Rs 500 to Rs 800 a month. In India there is no safe season to skip it.
- Check your dog after every walk in grass or scrub, and remove attached ticks with tweezers or a tick tool, holding close to the skin. Wash your hands after.
- Treat the environment too: wash bedding hot, vacuum, and keep grass short. Most of the flea life cycle lives off the animal.

What prevention actually costs

Product type	Typical cost in India	How often
Fipronil spot-on (most common)	Rs 400-900	Monthly
Broad-spectrum spot-on (fleas, ticks, mites)	Rs 800-1,500	Monthly
Preventive collar	Rs 1,500-3,500	Several months
Heartworm prevention	Rs 500-800	Monthly

Part 9 - Common Health Problems in Indian Dogs and Cats

Most of what sends Indian pets to the vet is preventable, and most of it is recognisable early if you know what you are looking at. Learn these, and you will catch problems while they are cheap to fix.

Problem	Signs	Prevention
Parvovirus	Bloody, foul diarrhoea and vomiting in an unvaccinated puppy; rapid collapse	Complete the puppy vaccine course to 16 weeks
Distemper	Fever, eye and nose discharge, coughing, then twitching or seizures	Core DHPPi vaccination
Kennel cough	A dry, honking cough after contact with other dogs	Kennel cough vaccine before boarding or daycare
Tick fever	Fever, swollen glands, lethargy, pale gums, nosebleeds	Monthly tick prevention; check after walks
Skin problems (fungal, mange, allergy)	Itching, hair loss, redness, scaly or smelly skin	Regular grooming, dry coat, prompt vet visit
Ear infection	Head shaking, scratching at the ear, discharge, smell	Clean ears monthly; dry them after bathing or swimming
Intestinal worms	Pot belly, dull coat, visible worms in stool, scooting	Deworm on schedule; dispose of stool promptly
Dental disease	Bad breath, brown tartar, drooling, difficulty eating	Brush teeth several times a week
Obesity	You cannot feel the ribs; no waist when seen from above	Measure food; limit treats; daily exercise
Arthritis (older pets)	Stiffness, reluctance to climb stairs, slower walks	Healthy weight; joint check at annual visits

Knowing when to rush and when to watch is most of the skill. Go to a vet the same day for: a pet that has stopped eating for more than 24 hours, repeated vomiting or diarrhoea, blood in vomit or stool, a distended hard abdomen, difficulty breathing, collapse or a seizure, a wound that will not stop bleeding, a cat straining to urinate, or any suspected poisoning. You can reasonably watch for a day for: a single soft stool in an otherwise bright animal, a mild itch with no hair loss, or a small limp that improves with rest. When in doubt, err toward going - a consultation fee is small next to the cost of waiting.

The one early-warning sign that matters most

A pet that stops eating, or is suddenly much quieter than usual, is telling you something. In dogs and cats, loss of appetite and lethargy are the commonest first signs of serious illness. Do not 'wait and see' for more than a day. An early vet visit costs a consultation; a late one costs an emergency.

Part 10 - Everyday Care: Grooming, Dental and Surviving an Indian Summer

Most of everyday care is unglamorous and cheap, and it prevents the expensive problems. The exception is heat, which in India can kill a dog in under an hour.

The grooming basics

- Bathe every three to four weeks at most, with a dog-specific shampoo. Human shampoo strips the coat and skin.
- Brush short coats weekly and long coats two to three times a week to prevent matting, which traps heat and hides ticks.
- Trim nails every three to four weeks. Overgrown nails change how the dog walks and cause joint pain.
- Clean ears monthly, and check for the dark discharge of ear mites.
- Brush teeth several times a week with pet toothpaste. Dental disease is common and drives heart and kidney problems later. Never use human toothpaste.

Heatstroke: recognise it, and act in seconds

A dog's normal temperature is about 38 to 39 degrees Celsius. Above 40 degrees it is a medical emergency. Flat-faced breeds are at the highest risk - an English Bulldog is roughly 14 times more likely to suffer heatstroke than a Labrador, a French Bulldog about six times. Heavy coats, obesity, old age and puppyhood all raise the risk.

Stage	Signs
Mild	Heavy panting, fast breathing, restlessness, low energy
Moderate	Thick drooling, vomiting, diarrhoea, red or very pale gums, wobbliness
Severe	Confusion, collapse, seizures, blood in vomit or stool, unconsciousness

Heatstroke first aid - cool first, transport second

Move the animal out of the heat and into shade or air-conditioning, but not directly in front of a blast of cold air.

Pour cool - not icy - water over the body, focusing on the neck, belly and inner thighs. Keep it away from the nose and mouth so the animal does not breathe it in.

Fan the animal, and place cool wet towels underneath it, not over it - covering an overheating dog traps heat.

Offer cool water but do not force it. Then get to a vet immediately, even if the animal seems to recover. Internal damage is often not visible.

Never leave any pet in a parked car, even for a few minutes with the windows down. On an Indian summer day the inside of a car can pass 50 degrees within minutes.

Summer routine

- Walk in the early morning and after sunset. Test the road with the back of your hand - if you cannot hold it there for seven seconds, it will burn paws.
- Always carry water. Use a harness rather than a collar on hot days; it puts less pressure on the throat and helps breathing.
- Never shave a double-coated breed to the skin; the coat insulates against heat as well as cold. Regular brushing does more good.

Part 11 - The Indian Pet Calendar: Care Through the Year

India's climate and festival calendar put a different demand on a pet in every season. Keep this page and check it at the turn of each season.

Season	Main risks	What to do
Winter (Dec-Feb)	Joint stiffness in older pets; wedding-season fireworks and drums	Warm bedding; joint check; plan for noise on wedding nights
Summer (Mar-Jun)	Heatstroke, burnt paws, dehydration, tick activity rising	Walks at dawn and dusk; water always; monthly tick prevention
Monsoon (Jul-Sep)	Leptospirosis from water and rat urine; fungal skin; tick explosion	Avoid stagnant water; dry the coat; keep tick prevention going; leptospirosis vaccine
Festive (Oct-Nov)	Diwali firecracker noise and mithai poisoning; Delhi-NCR smog affecting breathing	Safe room and early walks; no table food; limit outdoor time in heavy smog

Monsoon, in more detail

- Leptospirosis is spread through water contaminated by rat urine - puddles, flooded lanes and standing water are the risk. Keep your dog out of them, and ask your vet whether the leptospirosis vaccine is appropriate for your area.
- Wet coats breed fungal skin infections. Dry your pet thoroughly after every wet walk, especially the paws and between the toes.
- Ticks multiply in the warm, damp months, and this is when tick fever cases peak. Do not pause monthly prevention in the monsoon - increase vigilance.
- Paw care: wash muddy paws with plain water and dry them, and check for cuts and irritation.

Winter and the festive-wedding stretch

Older pets feel the cold in their joints; a warm, padded bed and a joint check at the annual visit help. The stretch from Diwali through the wedding season - roughly November to February, and again April to June - brings unpredictable fireworks and loud music, so a noise-anxious animal faces more than one bad night. The plan in Part 18 applies to every such night, not only Diwali.

Part 12 - Training and Behaviour Without Fear

Training is not about dominance. It is about teaching your pet what you want, rewarding it instantly, and being consistent. Punishment teaches fear, not behaviour, and fear is the root of most biting. Modern veterinary behaviourists recommend reward-based training for every animal.

The five commands worth teaching first

- **Sit** - the foundation of almost everything, and the polite way to greet.
- **Come** - the command that keeps your dog alive near traffic. Practise it with rewards, never with punishment, or the dog learns that coming to you ends in something unpleasant.
- **Stay** - builds slowly, in short sessions, starting at home.
- **Leave it** - the command that stops a dog eating a cracker off the road or a poisoned bait.
- **Toilet on cue** - take the puppy to the same spot, wait, reward instantly. Accidents are a timing problem, not a naughtiness problem.

How to train in a way that works

- Keep sessions to three to five minutes, several times a day. A long session teaches boredom, not obedience.
- Reward within one second of the behaviour. Timing is the whole skill.
- End every session on a success. Never end frustrated.
- One command, one word, used by everyone in the house. 'Down' and 'off' mean different things; pick one meaning and stick to it.

- Ignore the behaviour you do not want; reward the behaviour you do. Shouting is attention, and attention can be a reward.

Socialisation, and why timing matters

Between about three and fourteen weeks a puppy is most open to new experiences. Use that window: carry the pup to see traffic, children, umbrellas, loud sounds and different surfaces, before the vaccination course finishes and while it is still safe to do so in your arms. A well-socialised dog is calmer for life and far less likely to bite.

When behaviour needs a professional

If your dog growls, snaps or bites, if a cat stops using the litter tray and starts spraying, or if either animal shows sudden anxiety that is new in an older pet, see a veterinarian. Sudden behaviour change in an older animal can mean pain or illness, not 'naughtiness'. Note that pet insurance generally excludes behavioural treatment, so these costs come from your own pocket - which is one more reason to address them early.

Part 13 - Spay and Neuter: When, Why and the Myths

Spaying (females) and neutering (males) is the single most cost-effective decision in pet care, for your animal's health, its behaviour and India's overpopulation crisis, which leaves an estimated 80 million dogs and cats on the streets.

The benefits, plainly

- Spaying a female before her first heat sharply reduces the risk of mammary (breast) cancer, and removes entirely the risk of the life-threatening uterine infection called pyometra.
- Neutering a male removes the risk of testicular cancer, and reduces roaming, marking and fighting - the behaviours that get dogs hit by cars.
- Sterilised animals generally live longer. In India, sterilisation through an NGO or municipal clinic can cost as little as Rs 500 to Rs 2,000, against Rs 5,000 to Rs 10,000 at a private clinic.

When, roughly

The right age depends on size and breed, and only your vet can fix it precisely. As a guide, small-breed dogs (projected adult weight under about 20 kg) are often done at six months, or a female before her first heat; large-breed dogs are often done after growth stops, which can be between 9 and 15 months. Cats are commonly done by five months. Some large breeds carry a higher risk of joint disorders if sterilised very young, which is exactly why the timing should be a conversation, not a default.

What the day looks like

- The animal is usually admitted in the morning and comes home the same day or the next morning.
- Food is withheld for a few hours before surgery, as your vet directs.
- Expect drowsiness for a day, a small incision to keep clean and dry, and a cone if the animal licks at the wound.
- Full recovery is usually within five to seven days. Keep the animal calm and indoors, and check the wound daily.
- Energy needs fall by roughly 30 per cent after sterilisation, so reduce the food a little or the animal will gain weight.

Three myths, retired

'She should have one litter first.' False, and the opposite of the medical evidence - females spayed before their first heat are typically healthier.

'He will feel less of a male.' Animals have no concept of masculinity. Neutering does not change personality.

'It will make them fat and lazy.' Only if you overfeed. Energy needs drop by roughly 30 per cent after sterilisation, so adjust the food.

Part 14 - Registration, Licensing and Microchipping

Pet registration has moved from an optional formality to a legal duty with real fines in India's big cities. Do it early, because it also makes travel, insurance claims and recovering a lost pet far easier.

City	What is required	Cost / fine
Delhi (MCD)	Pet dog registration under the DMC Act, 1957, applied online; renewed yearly against the anti-rabies certificate	Rs 500 new and renewal; late fee Rs 100 per month
Mumbai (BMC)	Dog licence applied and renewed entirely online through the BMC portal	Fee as per BMC schedule; digital licence by email
Chennai (GCC)	Licence plus mandatory microchipping; leash and muzzle in public; rabies vaccination	Rs 5,000 fine unlicensed; Rs 10,000 for abandoning a registered pet; Rs 500 for unleashed

Microchipping - a rice-grain chip implanted under the skin, scanned to read your contact details and vaccination history - is spreading fast. Chennai made it compulsory in 2025 and had issued more than 73,000 licences and chips by early 2026. Nationally, the Animal Husbandry Ministry has directed municipal bodies to implant RFID chips in street dogs during their sterilisation surgeries and to record the data on the Bharat Pashudhan portal. The direction of travel is clear: chip your pet, register it, and keep the record current.

Why it is worth doing even where it is not enforced

- A microchipped pet that slips its collar at a festival is far more likely to be reunited with you.
- A current licence protects you in a dispute with a landlord or a resident welfare association about whether your pet is lawfully kept.
- Insurers often ask for proof of vaccination and identification.
- If you ever travel with your pet internationally, the microchip is the anchor of the health certificate.

The five documents to keep forever

1. The vaccination card, photographed onto your phone. 2. The municipal registration or licence. 3. The microchip number and registration details. 4. Sterilisation certificate. 5. Adoption or purchase papers. Together these cover travel, insurance, a lost-pet search and any dispute with a society or landlord.

Part 15 - Travelling With Your Pet: Trains, Planes and Cabs

India's travel rules for pets are specific, and turning up at the station or airport without the paperwork means your pet does not travel. Plan ahead.

By train (Indian Railways / IRCTC)

- Dogs and cats may travel in First AC or First Class only, and only when the whole four-berth cabin or two-berth coupe is allotted to one PNR. One dog per PNR.
- Puppies and kittens small enough for a basket may travel in any class, with a confirmed ticket.

- Book through the IRCTC website (Trains, then Dogs/Cats Booking), after the first chart is prepared and before the final chart. Charges are at luggage rates, non-refundable even if the train is cancelled.
- Carry a veterinary fitness certificate issued within 24-48 hours of travel and the vaccination card, and report to the luggage office at least three hours before departure.
- On some Vande Bharat sleeper routes there is an enclosed 'pet box' near the locomotive, booked offline at the parcel office, charged by weight (about Rs 30 per kg). Confirm availability at your station first.
- Travelling without a booking means a penalty of six times the luggage rate.

By air (Air India and Akasa)

Weight (pet + carrier)	How it travels
Up to 10 kg	In the cabin, economy class, in a soft carrier under the seat
10 kg to 32 kg	As checked baggage in an IATA crate
Over 32 kg	As cargo

- Air India's 'Paws on Board' allows one pet in the cabin per passenger and two per flight, only domesticated cats and dogs, at least eight weeks old, not pregnant and not sedated. Book at least 48 hours ahead and report three hours before departure.
- Domestic cabin travel on Air India costs Rs 7,500 plus taxes per sector; checked baggage about Rs 16,000.
- Flat-faced (brachycephalic) breeds cannot travel in the cargo hold because of the breathing risk, and in-cabin pets are not allowed on routes to the USA, Canada, Australia and the UK.
- You need a health and rabies certificate signed by a registered vet, issued within seven days of departure, plus an indemnity form.
- Akasa Air's 'Pets on Akasa' allows cats and dogs from three months, two in the cabin and one in cargo per flight.
- Do not sedate your pet for a flight. Sedated animals are not accepted under IATA standards, and sedation can be dangerous at altitude.

On the ground

Uber Pet runs in Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru for an extra fee, and a growing number of 'pet taxi' operators serve other cities. For a long journey, break it up, offer water at intervals, and never leave a pet in a parked car. For cats, travel is harder: keep the cat in a secure carrier, cover it with a light cloth to reduce stress, and never let a cat loose in a moving vehicle.

Taking a pet abroad

International pet travel is a months-long project, not a booking. Rules are set by the destination country, not by India, and they change often. Start three to six months ahead and confirm the current rules with the destination's embassy and with India's Animal Quarantine and Certification Service (AQCS) before you commit to anything.

- A microchip is usually the starting requirement - many countries will not accept a pet that is not chipped, and the chip often must be implanted before the rabies vaccination.
- A current rabies vaccination, and for many destinations a rabies antibody titre test (RNATT) with a waiting period afterwards, is standard.
- You will need an export permit or no-objection certificate from AQCS, plus a health certificate from a registered veterinarian issued close to departure.
- Some destinations require an import permit obtained before travel, and a few require quarantine on arrival. Budget for both.
- Airlines carry pets only on certain routes and aircraft, and flat-faced breeds face extra restrictions. Confirm with the airline in writing.

- Never sedate a pet for a flight. It is against IATA guidance and can be dangerous at altitude.

Part 16 - Boarding, Pet Sitters and Leaving Your Pet Behind

You will eventually travel without your pet. How you leave it determines whether it comes home happy or sick.

Boarding facilities

- Visit before you book. Look at where the animals are kept, how they are cleaned, and whether the staff handle them calmly.
- Ask who is on site at night, and what happens in a medical emergency. Get the name and number of the vet they use.
- Confirm the vaccination requirements - most facilities require current DHPPi, rabies and often kennel cough vaccines.
- Book early for Diwali, wedding season and school holidays. Festive weeks fill up and prices rise.
- A trial night, weeks in advance, tells you more than any review.

In-home pet sitters and neighbours

- For a cat, staying at home with a daily sitter is usually far less stressful than boarding.
- Leave written instructions: feeding amounts, medication, the vet's number, and your own contact number.
- Ask the sitter to send a photo or short video once a day. It reassures you and keeps them accountable.
- Introduce the sitter to your pet before you leave, so you are not handing a stranger the keys to a nervous animal.

A short trip, done well

For a healthy adult dog and a trip of a few days, a trusted sitter or a well-run boarding facility is fine. For a very young, very old or unwell animal, or one with separation anxiety, boarding can do real harm. In those cases, either take the pet with you or arrange for it to stay in its own home with someone it knows.

Part 17 - The Money: Real Costs and Pet Insurance

Nobody regrets money spent on a pet they love; people regret being surprised by it. Here is the honest arithmetic for India in 2026.

What a pet costs

Item	Typical India range	Frequency
Food	Rs 1,500 to Rs 7,000 a month, by breed size and brand	Monthly
Tick and flea prevention	Rs 400 to Rs 2,000 a month	Monthly
Heartworm prevention	Rs 500 to Rs 800 a month	Monthly
Vaccination	Rs 500 to Rs 1,500 per shot; Rs 2,500 to Rs 4,500 in year one	Annual
Deworming	Rs 150 to Rs 300 per dose	Every 3 months
Sterilisation	Rs 500 to Rs 2,000 (NGO) or Rs 5,000 to Rs 10,000 (private)	Once
Registration	About Rs 500 a year	Annual
Emergency fund	Keep Rs 20,000 to Rs 30,000 aside	Always

Add it up and the first year lands between roughly Rs 60,000 and Rs 1,00,000 for a small or medium breed, and Rs 80,000 to Rs 1,40,000 for a large one. Later years cost 40 to 60 per cent less, once the one-off costs are done. The most important line is the emergency fund, because a single parvovirus hospitalisation or swallowed

object can cost Rs 6,000 to Rs 18,000, and one surgery can cost far more.

Pet insurance, briefly

Pet insurance in India works on reimbursement: you pay the vet, then claim. Several IRDAI-regulated insurers now offer it, including HDFC ERGO's Paws n Claws, Bajaj General's Pet Insurance, Universal Sompo's Pet Assure and Digit's pet policy. Premiums are small - some surgery-only covers start around Rs 169 to Rs 200 a year for a young small dog - and the full customisable plans cost more.

Feature	How it usually works
Entry age	About 3 to 6 months old; pre-existing conditions excluded
Exit age	Around 10 to 12 years, by breed
What is covered	Accidents, illness, surgery, hospitalisation; optional OPD, third-party liability, lost-pet and funeral covers
What is not	Vaccination and routine care, pre-existing disease, cosmetic procedures, pregnancy, behavioural treatment
Basis	Reimbursement - you pay, then claim; a deductible usually applies

A simple rule

If your breed is expensive to treat, or you would struggle with a sudden Rs 40,000 bill, insurance is worth it. If not, self-insure: put the premium into a dedicated pet emergency fund and never touch it for anything else. Either way, do not be the family that has to choose between treatment and rent.

Part 18 - The Diwali Plan: Fireworks, Food and Fear

Diwali 2026 falls on Sunday 8 November. The five-day festival runs from Dhanteras on Friday 6 November to Bhai Dooj on Tuesday 10 November, and the firecrackers do not keep to one evening - expect noise from the 6th to the 10th, with the worst after the evening prayers on the 8th. If your pet is frightened of loud sound, this is not one bad night. It is a difficult week, and preparation beats reaction every time.

What the law allows in 2026

- The Supreme Court's judgment in Arjun Gopal v Union of India (October 2018) banned barium-based and non-certified crackers, permitted only 'green' crackers certified through CSIR-NEERI, and set bursting hours of 8 pm to 10 pm on Diwali. States set their own windows.
- The 1999 CPCB standard caps a single cracker at 125 dB(AI), or 145 dB(C), measured four metres away. A residential area is meant to sit at 55 dB by day and 45 dB at night - so even a legal cracker is dramatically louder than the background.
- In 2026 the Supreme Court asked the CPCB (in July and August) whether the noise limit could be partly relaxed for some crackers. As of late 2026 no order had changed the 125 dB standard, but the practical reading for a pet owner is to prepare for the possibility of a louder festival, not a quieter one.
- 'Green' is an emissions standard, not a noise standard. A green cracker is not a quiet cracker.

Why it is so much worse for them than for us

A dog's hearing runs from roughly 67 Hz to 45,000 Hz, against a human range of about 20 Hz to 20,000 Hz, and a cat's goes higher still. A cracker that is a bang to you is a full-strength explosion to them, and their ears pinpoint exactly where each one came from. Firework fear is common and it worsens with age: a large study of nearly 14,000 dogs found about 32 per cent were highly fearful of at least one noise, with fireworks the single most common fear at 26 per cent. Each unmanaged Diwali tends to make the next one harder.

The countdown - work backwards from 8 November

When	What to do
Now (late October)	Set up the safe room and let your pet use it on ordinary days, so it is familiar. Begin gentle desensitisation with firework sounds at low volume.
One to two weeks before	If last year was bad, see your vet now - prescriptions need a trial and consultations are hard to get during the festival week.
One week before	Update the ID tag with your current phone number and check the microchip details. Take a fresh, clear photo of your pet.
48 hours before	Shift walks to early morning and finish before dusk. Stock food and medicines so you need not go out at peak hours.
Diwali day	Long walk in the afternoon, main meal before sunset, last toilet trip on a leash before dark, then stay in.

Setting up the safe room

- Pick a room your pet already rests in, ideally one without a window facing the street. Close the windows and draw the curtains to muffle sound and block the flash of aerial fireworks.
- Put your pet's own bedding and a worn piece of your clothing inside, plus water. Leave the door open so the animal chooses to go in rather than feeling trapped.
- Turn on a fan or the television at normal volume before the noise starts. Do not blast music over the fireworks - that just adds noise.
- If you use a crate, leave it open and cover it on three sides so it feels like a den.

On the night

- Stay home if you can. Your calm presence is the most effective calming signal for most dogs. Sit near them and go about normal activity.
- Comforting a frightened dog does not 'reward the fear'. Sit with them, speak quietly, stroke them if they want it. What does not help is scolding, laughing, or carrying them outside to 'get used to it'.
- Let them hide under the bed or behind a door if that is where they feel safe. Do not force a frightened animal to sit still.
- Secure every door, gate and balcony. Most Diwali runaways begin with a door left open for guests or a slip at the building gate.
- Do not take your pet to watch fireworks, and never leave one on a balcony, terrace or tied up outside - not even for a few minutes.

Do not medicate without your vet

Never give your pet a human sleeping pill or anxiety tablet. A dose that is fine for you can be dangerous or fatal for an animal. Sedation is also not the same as calming: some older sedatives reduce movement without reducing fear, leaving the animal terrified but unable to react. If your pet needs medication, it is a conversation with your vet, weeks in advance.

If your pet runs

- Search close to home first and immediately: the parking levels, stairwells, under cars, behind the generator. Most dogs that bolt are found nearby, hiding somewhere dark.
- Post a clear photo and your phone number in your building and neighbourhood WhatsApp groups.
- Talk to the security guards of the buildings around you - they notice everything that moves at night.
- Go back out at dawn, when the streets are quiet, and call softly. Many frightened animals only come out once everything is silent.
- In the morning, call nearby vets and shelters in case someone has brought your pet in.

The morning after

For a few days the roads are littered with paper, wire and half-burnt crackers that smell of food. Keep the leash short and your eyes on the ground. Call a vet straight away if your pet has eaten any part of a cracker, sparkler or wire, has a burn (usually on the paws or face), has a red, watery or swollen eye, or is still vomiting, drooling heavily or shaking hours after the noise has stopped. Take the wrapper with you if you can.

Cats at Diwali, and the smog weeks

- Cats hide rather than bolt, so give them a wardrobe, a cupboard or a covered crate to retreat into, and do not drag them out.
- A cat that stops eating during the festive week is at risk within a couple of days - cats that go off food can develop liver problems quickly. See a vet.
- In Delhi-NCR, the weeks after Diwali bring heavy smog. Flat-faced and elderly pets, and those with heart or lung conditions, should be walked briefly and off peak-pollution hours, and kept indoors as much as possible.

Part 19 - Emergencies: The First Ten Minutes

In an emergency, panic costs time. Know these responses in advance, keep your vet's number and the nearest 24-hour clinic saved in your phone, and know the route before you need it.

Poisoning (something eaten)

- Note what was eaten, roughly how much, and when. Keep the wrapper or a sample.

- Do not induce vomiting unless a vet tells you to. Some substances do more damage coming back up, and some cause choking.
- Do not give milk, oil, salt or home remedies. Call your vet or an animal poison helpline and follow their instructions.

Bleeding, choking and bloat

Emergency	First response
Bleeding wound	Apply firm pressure with a clean cloth; do not remove an embedded object; get to a vet
Choking	Open the mouth and look; only remove an object you can clearly see and reach; never push it deeper; go to a vet at once
Bloat (swollen, hard abdomen, retching)	A life-threatening emergency in deep-chested dogs - go to a vet immediately, do not wait
Seizure	Do not hold the animal down or put your hand in its mouth; clear the area, time the seizure, call the vet
Heatstroke	Cool first with water and air movement, then transport - see Part 10
Road accident	Do not move the animal if a spine injury is possible; use a rigid board or blanket as a stretcher; cover to prevent shock; go to a vet

Basic CPR, if you must

- Lay the animal on its right side on a firm surface.
- Place your hands over the widest part of the chest, just behind the front legs, and compress firmly about 100 to 120 times a minute - roughly two per second.
- For a small pet, compress the chest with one hand; for a large dog, use both hands with straight arms.
- If you are trained, give rescue breaths as well. If not, do chest compressions alone and get to a vet immediately.
- CPR buys time. It is not a cure. Call ahead to the vet while someone drives.

The emergency kit worth keeping

Your vet's number and the nearest 24-hour clinic, saved and written down. A basic first-aid box: gauze, bandage, antiseptic (povidone-iodine), a thermometer, tweezers, a tick tool, saline, a muzzle or soft cloth, and a rigid board. Your pet's vaccination card, photographed. A bottle of clean water. That is the whole list, and it fits in one bag.

Part 20 - Cats: What Is Different

Cats are not small dogs, and the differences are not trivia - some of them are life and death. Cat ownership is growing faster than dog ownership in Indian cities, especially in smaller flats, so it is worth knowing the gaps.

- **Lilies can kill a cat.** Every part of a true lily and a daylily - petals, leaves, pollen, even the water in the vase - can cause fatal kidney failure within 24 to 72 hours. There is no such thing as a 'safe' lily in a cat's home. Keep them out entirely.
- **Paracetamol is fatal to cats.** Never give a cat any human painkiller.
- **Cats must eat meat-based diets.** They cannot make taurine and several other nutrients, so a vegetarian or vegan diet for a cat is not recommended except under a veterinary nutritionist's supervision.
- **Indoor cats live longer and are safer** from traffic, dog attacks, fights and disease, but they need play, climbing space and a litter tray kept clean.

- **Litter tray problems are usually medical first.** If a cat starts urinating outside the box, especially a male cat straining to pass urine, it can be a blockage that is fatal within a day or two. See a vet immediately.
- **Flea products are not interchangeable.** Some dog flea treatments are toxic to cats. Always check the label and ask your vet.
- **Cats need scratching posts and climbing space**, and they need their litter tray kept cleaner than most people think - one tray per cat, plus one, scooped daily.

A little enrichment goes a long way. Cats are hunters, and an indoor cat with nothing to chase, climb or scratch becomes bored, overweight and prone to stress behaviours. A tall scratching post, a window perch, a wand toy for ten minutes a day and a couple of food puzzles cost little and prevent a great deal. Two short play sessions a day, morning and evening, mimic a cat's natural hunting rhythm and are the single best thing you can do for an indoor cat's wellbeing.

Part 21 - Senior Pets: The Long, Kind Years

A pet is 'senior' earlier than most owners expect - roughly seven years for a large dog, eight to ten for a small dog or cat. The care does not get harder, it gets more deliberate.

- See the vet twice a year rather than once. Older animals hide illness well, and early blood tests catch kidney, liver and thyroid problems while they are manageable.
- Watch the weight in both directions. Unexplained weight loss is a red flag; weight gain worsens arthritis and heart strain.
- Keep the nails short and the bedding padded, and add ramps or low steps to help a stiff animal reach its favourite spots.
- Keep mental stimulation going - gentle sniffing walks, food puzzles - to slow cognitive decline.
- Ask your vet about joint support and a senior-appropriate diet.
- Watch for the signs of pain that owners miss: reluctance to climb stairs, slower walks, panting at rest, or a change in temperament.

Quality of life, honestly

At the end, the kindest question is not 'how long can we keep them going?' but 'is this still a good life?'. Ask your vet for an honest, unpressured conversation about quality of life - appetite, comfort, mobility, interest in the family. Good palliative care, including pain relief, is available in Indian cities, and it is a real option. Planning this in advance is one of the last loving things you can do.

Part 22 - Bringing a Baby Home to a Pet

A dog or cat does not automatically become a danger when a baby arrives, but the transition needs managing. The one absolute rule: never leave a baby or toddler alone with any pet, however gentle.

- Before the birth, change routines gradually - the walks, the feeding times, the sleeping spots - so the pet does not associate change with the baby.
- Let the pet smell a worn baby blanket before you bring the baby home.
- When you arrive, greet the pet first, calmly, with the baby in the other person's arms. Then allow a supervised sniff.
- Reward calm behaviour around the baby, and never scold the pet for being curious.
- Keep the pet's own space - its bed, its feeding area - as a no-go zone for the baby and for visiting children.
- Teach children from the start: never disturb a pet that is eating or sleeping, never pull ears or tails, and always ask before petting.

The 'breath-stealing' myth

The old belief that cats smother babies is false, and has cost many cats their homes. A cat may curl up for warmth, but it will not 'steal a baby's breath'. The real, sensible precautions are simple: keep the pet out of the cot, cover the cot or use a net, and supervise every interaction. The risk to manage is a scratch or a nip, not a myth.

Part 23 - Community Animals and the ABC Rules

India's street dogs are governed by the Animal Birth Control Rules, 2023, notified under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960. Every pet parent who feeds a community dog, or is worried about one, should know the basics.

- The law's method is sterilise, vaccinate and release back to the same locality - not relocation and not culling. The Supreme Court reaffirmed in 2025 that dogs that are sterilised, dewormed and vaccinated are released back where they were picked up, except those that are rabid or dangerously aggressive.
- Relocation of community dogs is not permitted. If a dog is being taken away from your locality, that is contrary to the Rules and to the court's directions.
- Under Rule 20, the resident welfare association or apartment owners' association is responsible for arranging feeding of community animals, and an animal welfare committee is meant to resolve disputes between feeders and residents.
- The 2025 directions also asked municipal bodies to create designated feeding areas and dedicated helplines, and to keep records.
- You can adopt a street dog. The court expressly allowed animal lovers to apply to the municipal body to adopt a tagged street dog, on condition that the dog does not return to the streets.

If you feed a community dog

Feed in one agreed spot at a fixed time, keep it clean, and do not leave food scattered where it causes complaints. Register the dog for the local ABC and anti-rabies programme so it is sterilised and vaccinated - this protects both the dog and your neighbourhood, and it is the single most effective rabies measure there is. If you face pressure to remove the dog, point to the ABC Rules, 2023 and the 2025 Supreme Court directions.

Part 24 - Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
A dog should have one litter before being spayed	False. Females spayed before their first heat are typically healthier and face far lower mammary cancer risk.
Garlic prevents fleas	False and dangerous - garlic damages red blood cells. Use proper tick and flea products.
Home-cooked food is always healthier than packet food	Not automatically. Most home recipes are deficient in protein, taurine or micronutrients. Packet diets labelled 'complete and balanced' are nutritionally reliable.
A wagging tail means a friendly dog	Not always. A high, stiff wag can signal arousal or tension. Read the whole body, not the tail alone.
A wet nose means the pet is healthy	False. Nose moisture is not a health indicator. Appetite, energy and gum colour are far more useful.
One human year equals seven dog years	Only roughly. Dogs mature much faster in the first two years, then age more slowly; small breeds live far longer than large ones.
A foaming dog is the only rabid dog	False. Rabies can present with behaviour change, paralysis or difficulty swallowing. Any dog bite in India is treated as a potential exposure.
Cats can live on a vegetarian diet like the family	Not safely. Cats need nutrients found in animal tissue. A vegetarian cat diet should only be attempted under a veterinary nutritionist.

Part 25 - Your First-Year Cost Sheet and 30-Day Action Plan

First-year budget, by breed size (India, 2026)

Line	Small (under 10 kg)	Medium (10-25 kg)	Large (25 kg+)
Food	Rs 18,000-30,000	Rs 30,000-48,000	Rs 48,000-84,000
Vaccination	Rs 2,500-4,500	Rs 2,500-4,500	Rs 2,500-4,500
Parasite prevention	Rs 6,000-10,000	Rs 6,000-12,000	Rs 8,000-16,000
Sterilisation	Rs 2,000-8,000	Rs 5,000-10,000	Rs 8,000-15,000
Supplies (crate, bowls, leash, toys)	Rs 5,000-10,000	Rs 6,000-12,000	Rs 8,000-15,000
Registration	About Rs 500	About Rs 500	About Rs 500
Emergency fund (keep separate)	Rs 20,000-30,000	Rs 20,000-30,000	Rs 30,000-40,000

Subsequent years run 40 to 60 per cent lower, because the crate, the sterilisation and the first-year vet work are done.

Your 30-day action plan

1. **Day 1.** Register with a vet you trust and save the number. Start the vaccination and deworming schedule.
2. **Day 2-3.** Set up the safe room, the bed and the feeding spot. Puppy-proof the house.
3. **Day 4-7.** Begin the routine: fixed meal times, fixed toilet spot, short training sessions.
4. **Week 2.** Apply municipal registration and microchipping. Order the monthly parasite prevention.
5. **Week 3.** Start gentle socialisation and, if you have a female, discuss the spay timing with your vet.
6. **Week 4.** Review the Diwali plan (Part 18) and, if you are a first-time owner, put the emergency numbers and the nearest 24-hour clinic in your phone.

Appendix A - Choosing the Right Pet for Your Home

The right pet is the one that fits your real life, not the one you saw online. Use this table before you decide.

Your situation	A good fit	Think twice about
Small flat, long work hours, first pet	Adult indie or a calm adult cat; a mature rescue dog already house-trained	High-energy puppies, working breeds, very large dogs
Family with young children	Medium-energy, patient adult dog; gentle breeds with a calm temperament	Very small fragile breeds, or a dog with a bite history
Hot climate city (Chennai, Mumbai, Delhi)	Indies, short-coated breeds adapted to heat	Flat-faced (brachycephalic) breeds - high heatstroke risk
Senior citizen living alone	A calm small or medium adult dog, or a mature cat	Large, strong or highly energetic dogs that could pull you over
You travel often	A cat, or a dog that takes well to a trusted sitter or boarding	A dog with severe separation anxiety
Tight budget	An indie: low grooming cost, fewer inherited health problems	Breeds prone to expensive inherited conditions

Ask the shelter or breeder the hard questions

How is the animal with children, other dogs and cats? Has it been around traffic and noise? Is it house-trained? Why is it being rehomed? A rescue group will usually answer these honestly, because a failed adoption is bad for everyone, including the animal.

Appendix B - Training Problem-Solving: The Six You Will Meet

Problem	Why it happens	What to do
Puppy biting hands	Normal play and teething; the pup has not learned bite inhibition	Yelp and stop play for a few seconds; redirect to a chew toy; never hit
Chewing furniture and shoes	Boredom, teething, or not enough appropriate things to chew	More exercise and chew toys; remove temptations; reward chewing the right thing
Pulling on the leash	The dog has learned that pulling gets it where it wants	Stop walking the moment the leash tightens; reward a loose leash; try a front-clip harness
Excessive barking	Alerting, boredom, fear or attention-seeking	Identify the trigger; reward quiet; more exercise; do not shout - it reads as joining in
Jumping on people	Greeting behaviour that has been rewarded with attention	Turn away and ignore until all four paws are down, then greet and reward
Separation anxiety	Genuine distress at being left alone; common in rescues	Practise short absences, build up slowly, leave a worn item; see a vet or behaviourist for severe cases

The rule behind all six

Reward the behaviour you want within a second; make the behaviour you do not want unrewarding. Punishment, shouting and hitting do not teach a pet what to do - they teach fear, and fear is the root of most biting. If a problem does not improve in a few weeks of consistent, reward-based work, that is a veterinary behaviour case, not a discipline problem.

Appendix C - Understanding Your Vet and the Bill

A good vet is your pet's most valuable asset. Knowing how a bill is built, and what to ask, helps you get good care without overspending.

- Consultation fees in Indian cities typically run Rs 200 to Rs 800. Diagnostics and treatment are billed on top.
- Ask for a written estimate before any procedure. A reasonable clinic will give one.
- Ask what is essential today and what can wait, and what each item costs. You are allowed to know.
- For a major surgery or a serious diagnosis, a second opinion is normal and sensible, not an insult.
- Keep every bill and prescription - pet insurance claims in India are reimbursement-based and need documents.
- Ask which vaccines and treatments your pet actually needs for your area, rather than accepting a standard package unexamined.

Questions worth asking at every visit

What is the diagnosis, and how certain is it? What are the treatment options, and the cost of each? What happens if we wait? What should I watch for at home? When should I come back? Write the answers down, or ask the vet to note them on the prescription - memory fails in a stressful consultation.

Appendix D - 40 Questions New Pet Parents Ask

Vaccination and health

- **When should my puppy have its first vaccine?** Around 6 to 8 weeks, with the final dose at 14 to 16 weeks.
- **Is the rabies vaccine compulsory?** It is expected and required for registration and travel in India, and it protects people as well as the animal.
- **Do I need to repeat vaccines every year?** Rabies and leptospirosis annually; the core viral vaccine no more often than every three years after the first-year booster.
- **How do I know if my pet is in pain?** Reluctance to move or climb, panting at rest, a change in appetite or temperament, and hiding.
- **Is a warm nose a sign of fever?** No. Feel the ears and use a thermometer; normal is about 38 to 39 degrees Celsius.
- **How often should I deworm my pet?** Monthly in the first six months, then every three months.
- **My dog is scratching a lot - why?** Usually fleas, a fungal infection, mange or an allergy. See a vet rather than guessing.

Food and feeding

- **Can I feed my dog only rice and dal?** Not safely - it is too low in protein. Add paneer, curd, egg or a complete commercial food.
- **Can dogs eat roti?** Plain roti as a small treat is fine; it should not be the main diet.
- **Is milk good for cats?** Most adult cats are lactose intolerant. Plain water is better.
- **How much should I feed?** Follow the food packet's weight chart and your vet; measure, do not guess.
- **Can I give my pet my leftover curry?** No - it usually contains onion and garlic, both toxic, and too much oil and salt.
- **My cat has stopped eating - is that serious?** Yes. Cats that go off food can develop liver problems within days. See a vet quickly.

Behaviour and daily life

- **Should I punish my dog for an accident indoors?** No. It teaches fear, not toilet training. Clean it, take the dog out more often, reward success.
- **Why does my dog follow me everywhere?** Normal attachment, or the start of separation anxiety if it panics when you leave.

- **Will neutering calm my dog?** It often reduces roaming, marking and fighting; it does not change personality.
- **How often should I bathe my dog?** Every three to four weeks at most, with pet shampoo.
- **Can my cat be an indoor cat?** Yes, and indoor cats live longer, but they need play, climbing space and a clean litter tray.
- **How do I stop my puppy biting?** Yelp, pause the play, and redirect to a chew toy. Never hit.

Costs, law and travel

- **Do I have to register my dog?** In most big cities, yes - Delhi, Mumbai and Chennai all require it, with fines for non-compliance.
- **What does a dog cost in the first year?** Roughly Rs 60,000 to Rs 1,00,000 for a small or medium breed, plus an emergency fund.
- **Is pet insurance worth it?** It is if your breed is expensive to treat or a sudden Rs 40,000 bill would hurt. Otherwise, self-insure into a pet fund.
- **Can my dog travel in the train?** Yes, in First AC or First Class with the whole cabin, or as a booked pet box on some routes, with a fitness certificate.
- **Can my dog fly in the cabin?** On Air India and Akasa, yes, if the pet and carrier together weigh up to 10 kg.
- **Do I need a vet certificate to travel?** Yes - a fitness and rabies certificate, issued shortly before travel.
- **Where do I leave my pet when I travel?** A trusted sitter for cats; a visited and vetted boarding facility for dogs; book early in festive weeks.

The ones people are embarrassed to ask

- **Is it cruel to keep a dog in a flat?** Not if it gets proper walks, exercise and company. A flat is fine; a bored dog is not.
- **Do dogs really need walks every day?** Yes - at least twice a day for most dogs, and more for energetic breeds.
- **Can I leave my dog alone all day while I work?** An adult dog can cope for a working day if it has had a walk, water and something to do, but not every day indefinitely.
- **What if I can no longer keep my pet?** Do not abandon it - that is now a fined offence in some cities. Rehome through a rescue group and be honest about why.
- **How do I know if my pet is happy?** Good appetite, interest in the family, play, a normal coat and steady weight. Changes in any of these are your signal to look closer.

Appendix E - Printable Diwali Safety Checklist

Print this page, or copy it into your phone, and tick it off as you go.

One month before (early October)

- Set up the safe room and let your pet use it on ordinary days.
- Begin gentle desensitisation with firework sounds at low volume.
- If last Diwali was bad, book a vet consultation now.

One week before

- Check the ID tag shows your current phone number.
- Confirm the microchip is registered to your current number.
- Take a fresh, clear photo of your pet for a lost-pet poster.
- Book boarding now if you are travelling - festive weeks fill up.

Diwali day

- Long walk in the afternoon, while it is still quiet.
- Main meal finished a couple of hours before sunset.
- Last toilet trip on a leash before dark.
- Windows closed, curtains drawn, fan or TV on at normal volume.
- Safe room open, with bedding, water and a worn item of your clothing.
- Every door, gate and balcony secured.
- Tell every guest: do not feed the pet, and do not leave doors open.

After the fireworks

- Keep the leash short on walks - watch for cracker residue, wire and glass.
- Check paws and the face for burns or cuts.
- If your pet ate any part of a cracker or is still unwell hours later, call a vet.
- Keep the next few days calm, especially if your pet is still jumpy.

The three things that matter most

A safe room prepared weeks in advance, an up-to-date ID and microchip, and staying home and calm on the loudest night. Everything else is a bonus.

Appendix F - Your Pet's Records and Reminders

Fill this in when you bring your pet home, and update it at every vet visit. Keep a photograph of it on your phone.

Record	Details to fill in
Pet's name, species, breed	
Date of birth / approximate age	
Microchip number	
Municipal registration / licence number	
Your vet: name, clinic, phone	
Nearest 24-hour emergency vet	
Rabies vaccine: date given, next due	
Core vaccine: date given, next due	
Deworming: last done, next due	
Tick and flea prevention: product, next due	
Weight at last visit	
Allergies or ongoing conditions	
Insurance policy number and helpline	

Set four phone reminders today

1. The next vaccination date. 2. The monthly tick and flea treatment. 3. The quarterly deworming. 4. The annual registration renewal. Four reminders, set once, prevent the four most common and most avoidable lapses in pet care.

Appendix G - Where to Get Help in India

These are the official and reliable places to look when you need a rule, a record or a rescue.

You need	Where to go
A rule on street dogs or breeding	Animal Welfare Board of India (awbi.gov.in) - the ABC Rules 2023, Dog Breeding Rules 2017 and Pet Shop Rules 2018
Rabies information and bite guidance	National Rabies Control Programme (rabiesfreeindia.mohfw.gov.in), Ministry of Health and Family Welfare
To register your pet dog	Your municipal corporation's online portal - MCD for Delhi, BMC for Mumbai, GCC for Chennai, and equivalents in other cities
To travel with a pet by train	IRCTC website, Trains then Dogs/Cats Booking
To travel with a pet by air	Air India 'Paws on Board' and Akasa 'Pets on Akasa' pages
Pet insurance	IRDAI-regulated insurers - HDFC ERGO, Bajaj General, Universal Sompo, Digit
To adopt or foster	AWBI-recognised animal welfare organisations, municipal pounds and local rescue groups

The one number to save first

Before anything else, save the number and address of the nearest 24-hour veterinary clinic. Emergencies do not happen in office hours. Knowing where to drive at 2 am, before you need to, is worth more than any other single preparation in this book.

Appendix H - The First-Year Month-by-Month Planner

A simple timeline for a puppy or kitten. Your vet's schedule overrides this if they differ - it is a planning aid, not a prescription.

When	What happens
Month 1 (6-8 weeks)	First DHPPi / Tricat vaccine; first deworming; settle-in and puppy-proofing; start toilet routine
Month 2 (10-12 weeks)	Second vaccine; rabies vaccine from 12 weeks; second deworming; begin gentle socialisation in arms
Month 3 (14-16 weeks)	Final puppy/kitten core vaccine - do not skip this one; municipal registration and microchipping
Month 4 (16-20 weeks)	Discuss spay/neuter timing; start formal training; begin short walks once fully vaccinated
Month 5-6	Sterilisation for small breeds and cats; monthly deworming continues; first grooming routine established
Month 7-9	Large-breed sterilisation timing decided with your vet; adult food transition; ongoing training
Month 10-12	First annual health check; core vaccine booster at one year; rabies booster; review weight and diet

The two dates never to miss

The final puppy or kitten core vaccine at 14 to 16 weeks, and the rabies booster at one year. Get them wrong and the animal is either unprotected or outside the law. Put both in your phone calendar the day you bring the pet home.

Appendix I - Home Safety and Pet-Proofing Checklist

Walk through your home once with this list, and again whenever a pet is new or a baby starts crawling.

- Electrical wires and chargers covered, tucked away or run through conduit.
- Medicines, cleaning fluids, phenyl and cosmetics on a high shelf or in a closed cupboard.
- Human foods that are toxic - chocolate, raisins, onion, garlic, xylitol - out of reach, and guests told not to feed the pet.
- Lilies and other toxic plants removed entirely from a home with a cat.

- Shoes, socks, plastic bags, hair ties, rubber bands and sanitary items out of reach - these cause blockages that need surgery.
- Bin lids secure, especially kitchen bins that hold bones and wrappers.
- Balconies and windows netted or blocked; grills checked for gaps.
- Toilet lids down (small pets and kittens can drown), and washing machines and dryers checked before closing.
- Hot surfaces - stoves, irons, hot water - guarded from a curious nose.
- A quiet, safe retreat the pet can go to when it wants to be left alone, and which children are taught to respect.
- Your vet's number and the nearest 24-hour clinic on the fridge and in every adult's phone.

The five-minute rule for a new puppy or kitten

Get down on the floor at the pet's eye level and look around. Anything you can see and reach from down there is something the pet will eventually chew, eat or pull down. Move it. That one exercise prevents most household accidents.

Appendix J - Coat Care by Breed Type

Grooming needs vary enormously, and getting it wrong causes matting, skin problems and unnecessary expense. Find your pet's coat type below.

Coat type	Examples	Grooming routine
Short, single coat	Indie, boxer, beagle, pug, most cats	Brush weekly; bathe every 4 weeks; minimal shedding to manage
Double coat	Husky, spitz, German shepherd, Pomeranian	Brush 2-3 times a week; never shave to the skin; expect heavy seasonal shedding
Long, silky coat	Shih tzu, Lhasa apso, cocker spaniel, Persian cat	Brush daily; professional trim every 4-6 weeks to prevent matting
Curly or woolly coat	Poodle, poodle crosses	Brush every other day; professional trim every 4-6 weeks
Hairless or very short	Few breeds	Protect from sun and cold; bathe gently; use pet-safe sunscreen on exposed skin

Two grooming mistakes to avoid

Never shave a double-coated breed to the skin in summer - the coat insulates against heat as well as cold, and shaving it can leave the pet hotter and sunburnt. And never use human shampoo or human toothpaste on a pet; both are too harsh, and human toothpaste can be toxic if swallowed.

Appendix K - The Two-Page Summary

If you read nothing else, read this. It is the whole book in one place.

Health

- Complete the puppy or kitten core vaccine course, with the final dose at 14 to 16 weeks, then booster at one year. Rabies from 12 weeks, then annually.
- Deworm monthly to six months, then every three months for life.
- Monthly tick and flea prevention and monthly heartworm prevention, all year, in every Indian climate.
- Keep the vaccination card photographed on your phone, and set reminders for the next due dates.
- A pet that stops eating or is suddenly much quieter needs a vet, not a wait.

Safety

- Chocolate, raisins, onion, garlic, xylitol and lilies are dangerous. Tell every guest not to feed the pet.
- Cool first, transport second, for heatstroke - cool water on the body, air movement, then a vet.
- Never give a pet human medicine. Never leave a pet in a parked car.
- Microchip and tag your pet, and keep the registration current.

The Diwali week (6 to 10 November 2026)

- Prepare the safe room weeks early, not on the night.
- Walk and feed in the afternoon, and finish the last toilet trip before dark.
- Close windows and curtains, keep the fan or TV on at normal volume, stay calm and stay near.
- If the pet runs, search the building and the dark corners first, post a photo, and look again at dawn.

If a person is bitten

- Wash with soap and running water for 15 minutes, apply antiseptic, and go to a hospital the same day - in India, every dog or cat bite is treated as a potential rabies exposure.

The four things to do this week

Save the nearest 24-hour vet's number. Photograph the vaccination card. Set the next vaccination and monthly parasite reminders. Read the Diwali plan. Do these four and you have done more than most new pet parents ever do.

Part 26 - Quick Reference, Glossary and Sources

Quick reference card

If this happens	Do this
Person bitten by a dog or cat	Wash with soap and running water 15 minutes, apply antiseptic, go to hospital the same day
Pet ate chocolate, raisins or a sweet	Note the amount, do not induce vomiting, call the vet at once
Pet overheating in summer	Cool with water and air movement first, then transport to a vet
Pet panicking at fireworks	Safe room, close windows and curtains, stay calm and stay near
Pet has eaten a cracker or wire	Go to a vet immediately; take the wrapper if you can
Cat ate any part of a lily	A medical emergency - go to a vet now, do not wait for symptoms
Tick found on the pet	Remove with tweezers close to the skin, wash hands, keep monthly prevention going

Glossary

- **Core vaccine** - a vaccine every dog or cat should receive because the disease is widespread and dangerous.
- **DHPPi** - the combined canine core vaccine against distemper, hepatitis, parvovirus and parainfluenza.
- **PEP** - post-exposure prophylaxis, the rabies treatment given after a bite.
- **Brachycephalic** - flat-faced breeds with shortened airways, at higher risk of breathing and heat problems.
- **ABC Rules** - the Animal Birth Control Rules, 2023, which govern how Indian municipalities manage street dogs.
- **CPCB** - the Central Pollution Control Board, which sets India's firecracker noise limits.
- **Microchip** - an implanted chip holding your pet's ID and vaccination details, read by a scanner.
- **WSAVA** - the World Small Animal Veterinary Association, whose vaccination guidelines Indian vets follow.

Sources

Every fact in this playbook is drawn from primary and official sources, current as of October 2026.

- World Small Animal Veterinary Association - Vaccination Guidelines for Dogs and Cats, and the recommendations for Asian small animal practitioners.
- World Health Organization - Rabies fact sheet (September 2026) and rabies vaccination guidance; India's National Rabies Control Programme (NRCP) and National Action Plan for Dog-Mediated Rabies Elimination (NAPRE), Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.
- Supreme Court of India - Arjun Gopal v Union of India (firecracker rules) and the 2025 stray-dog directions; Central Pollution Control Board noise standards under the Environment (Protection) Rules, 1999 (GSR 682(E)).
- Animal Welfare Board of India and the Department of Animal Husbandry and Dairying - Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (Dog Breeding and Marketing) Rules, 2017, the PCA (Pet Shop) Rules, 2018 and the Animal Birth Control Rules, 2023.
- Municipal Corporation of Delhi pet registration portal; Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation dog licence portal; Greater Chennai Corporation licensing and microchipping notifications.
- Indian Railways / IRCTC pet booking rules; Air India 'Paws on Board' and Akasa 'Pets on Akasa' pet policies.
- IRDAI-regulated insurers - HDFC ERGO Paws n Claws, Bajaj General Pet Insurance, Universal Sompo Pet Assure and Digit Pet Insurance policy documents.
- ASPCA, AVMA, FDA, Merck Veterinary Manual, VCA and Cornell University for toxicology, nutrition and disease guidance; peer-reviewed studies in Scientific Reports and Indian veterinary journals for prevalence data.

A last word

A pet is the best thing most Indian homes will ever take on, and the easiest thing to get wrong quietly. Read the Diwali section tonight, get the vaccination schedule onto the calendar, save the emergency numbers, and keep the vaccination card photographed. Do those four things and you are already a better pet parent than most.

This playbook is general guidance, not veterinary advice for your specific animal. When your vet and this book disagree, your vet is right.